

might still want to pay attention to these guidelines which, at the very minimum, will ensure that you don't accidentally get blacklisted.

While all these techniques are applicable to some degree to the Big Three (Google, Yahoo!, and Windows Live), the emphasis given by each will vary. To a large extent we have kept Google in mind, considering that they hold the largest market share.

Content Relevance

Content is still king. Nothing increases your search engine rankings like relevant, on-topic, in-context content. All the other factors you need to pay attention to will carry no weight if you do not have relevant content. Even if you have a poorly-designed site, but with content that is useful to your visitors, search engines can be very forgiving and push you up the rankings, especially if a lot of other Web sites link to your site referring to it as an authority in the specific subject area.

Linking

Link Popularity is one of the main criteria in judging the relevance of a site. This is based on the assumption that if you have good, high-quality, authoritative content, more people will link to you. This might give some the idea that many dummy sites linking to your site can artificially inflate your rankings. Not any more. Search engines have wised up to this technique—known as link farming—and will actually penalise you if they detect that you're using link farms. What counts are organic links, that is, links to your sites by other sites that are in context.

Search engines not only count the links to your site but also look at the surrounding words to identify the context in which the link is placed. For example, if you are running a motorbike forum and you are linked to from a tech blog, a plain link to your Web site in the links section will carry less weight than if you were mentioned in a blog post. Of course, the exception is if a number of bloggers link to your forum, and a large percentage of them are passionate bikers with posts on biking. Secondly, the "anchor text" for the link also plays a part in determining the value of the link. "Check this out" will have less weightage than "Check out Rajesh's Motorcycle Forum". The link anchor text "this" is less descriptive and of insignificant context when compared to "Rajesh's Motorcycle Forum", and hence will have lesser value.

Of course, you have no control over how a blogger or another Web site will link to you, but you can at least do some groundwork (run a search for `link:yourdomain_dot_domain_extension` in Google) and politely request the Webmasters or bloggers you can reach if they would be so kind as to edit the anchor text.

While link farming is dead, there is still some life left in "reciprocal linking." This is where you agree with another Web site to show their links on your Web site in exchange for linking to your site. Note, however, that this should be done intelligently, or you might run foul of the search engines and get blacklisted. Stick to sites and blogs that are in topic and context with your site. Linking

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from a site on, say, Ayurvedic medicine will have no value, and links from many such non-relevant sites may end up getting treated as link spam, attracting penalties and even blacklisting.

One other technique is to participate in other forums, write articles for other Web sites, and/or leave comments on blogs. You may use these to provide links to your site, but ensure that the links are in context and provide value to the conversation. If you simply pop into a comment thread and say "Hey, check out my motorcycle forum" and leave a link, you will quickly get flagged for comment spam. Look for articles or blogs on motorcycles (our example) and leave an intelligent comment linking to a thread in your forum where they discussed the same issue—or something similar.

Links (and therefore the site it is linked to) gain value in other ways too:

- ☐ the older they are,
- ☐ if they are located higher up on a page than towards the bottom,
- ☐ if its part of the content (higher value) as against it being in a collection of other links like in a business directory listing (lower value), and
- ☐ if the link is from an authority site on the subject.

While all these links are something you have no direct control over, what you can ensure is that you have relevant on-topic content that creates the environment that will influence others to link to your content.

W3C Compliance And Site Structure

The one cardinal rule that all search engines insist on is that your Web site be primarily designed for humans and not search engines. The easiest way to do this is to bring your site into W3C (World Wide Web Consortium) compliance. The W3C is the standards body that defines development standards for Web technologies, and making your site W3C-compliant will give you a boost in the rankings with at least one of the search engines (Yahoo!). There are many validation tools that you can use to find out how compliant (or non-compliant) your Web site is. A basic "validator" for individual Web pages is available at <http://validator.w3.org>.

Bringing your site into W3C compliance is hard. The upside, though, is that when used in combination with CSS (Cascading Style Sheets), you can get a much cleaner and better-performing site. In addition, from an SEO perspective, the actual content will move up higher in the page code and hence be treated as more valuable by the search engines.

From a pure SEO perspective, compliance is not the holy grail to climbing up the SERP. The objective behind attempting to become compliant is that it ensures that the copy is marked up so that it is "clear" to search engines. Achieving compliance also ensures better compatibility with mobile devices, with less chances of the code not working in mobile browsers. In any case, the point is to minimise errors rather than seek to achieve full compliance overnight.

